there's only a minor irritant: a fine and fulfilment of certain conditions such as parking. Where space for the latter will come from is not covered in the draft.

Also, to claim amnesty under Section 15.38, violators have to only produce receipts of commercial property rent and commercial electricity bills, both issued ironically by utilities whose job it was to crack down on illegal structures. The solution, after decades of winking at rampant misuse of residential areas, has residents enraged. "Quality of civic life has been wrecked for years. Now the government plans to reward the law breakers," says civic activist Kamal Rathi. The intentions were never too covert. Except for one day in early August, no structure was sealed or closed, as the SC had ordered. Yes, a total of 8,000 notices were served. Violators even held demonstrations.

AN IMPLICIT LOSS

While bemoaning the loss of sanctity as a residential area, Rathi also cites a more material damage. "Commercial activity should either be totally disallowed in RG 3—or formally allowed for everyone, linked to road width, as in the rest of Bhopal. Then, a resident would have the choice of liquidating the asset and moving out. Right now, ordinary residents will suffer congestion, air and sound pollution, and have their property prices suppressed. Who would want to buy a house to live in a marketplace—one that you can't even convert?"

The Plan proposes a 51-km growth corridor where high-density mixed land use would be allowed. Plan Area has been expanded from 601 sq km to 1,016 sq km, covering 254 villages around the city, with a projected population of 4.5 million. Green cover is upped to 27 per cent from 16 per cent. Environmentalist Subhash Pandey isn't impressed. "In the early 1990s, green cover was 66 per cent. My latest 2021 study says it's down to 4 per cent in the city area. The claim seems implausible given the rate of destruction," he says. Attempts to contact Neeraj Lekhar, joint director, Town and Country Planning, did not succeed. ■

RAJASTHAN

GIRL CHILD BEARS THE BURDEN

Rajasthan goes against national trend as fertility rate edges up, along with adolescent pregnancies

By **Rohit Parihar**

RAJASTHAN'S LATEST FAMILY HEALTH indices have thrown up uncomfortable data. The percentage of girls aged 15-19 who were mothers or pregnant when surveyed rose from 3.7 per cent in NFHS-5 to 4.7 per cent in NFHS-6. That is, between the survey periods 2019-21 and 2023-24. This is a reversal of trend: the figure had fallen from 6.3 per cent in NFHS-4 (2015-16). The total fertility rate (TFR) also edged up from 2.0 to 2.1 children per woman. The proportion of women aged 20-24 who were underage when they got married declined marginally, from 25.4 per cent to 24.6 per cent.

Takeaways

- **NFHS-6 shows rise in rate of under-19 maternity, up from 3.7% to 4.7%**
- **Fertility also rises from 2 to 2.1 children per woman, child marriage is a factor**
- **Activists cite need for awareness and access to modern contraceptives**

On the seemingly contrary movement of the two trends, Jaipur-based clinical psychologist Saumya Sharma says the two indicators are not measuring the same population or the same phenomenon. The child-marriage indicator asks women aged 20-24 if they were married before 18—that is, a minimum of two years and potentially well over six years before the survey. The other measures those aged 15-19 at the time of the survey. "A decline in one therefore does not mean the other must decline," she says.

HURDLE TO MODERNITY

Dr Harchand Ram, population expert and assistant professor, Institute of Development Studies, Jaipur, adds a note of caution. "The rise in fertility is minor," he says. "We should wait for the Census to verify it and draw a conclusion." However, fertility edging up also beats the trend seen across India. Rajasthan's TFR had fallen sharply from 2.4 in NFHS-4. "We must analyse changes in marriage patterns, pregnancy frequency, contraceptive use and access, and regional concentrations," says Sharma. "Early pregnancy, advocated by some to counter falling birth rates, can negate all efforts to bring women into higher education and the organised work force." Among married women in Rajasthan, use of modern contraception fell from 62.1 per cent to 57.1 per cent, even as overall contraceptive use rose.

With adolescent pregnancies, and child marriage still a social phenomenon, gaps in awareness and access may be a challenge not entirely relegated to the past. ■